

Enticed by balls, eagle pounces on beach

Charlotte observer August 23, 2001



DAVE LANE - ASSOCIATED PRESS PHOTO

A bald eagle treated and released by the Carolina Raptor Center swoops down and claws 3-year-old Kayla Finn at Hampton Beach, N.H. The beach-loving eagle eluded state, federal and local wildlife officials for five days before it was captured Wednesday.

*N.C. bird dive-bombs
New England tourists
before being captured*

BY BRUCE HENDERSON
Staff Writer

A young bald eagle treated and released by the Carolina Raptor Center near Charlotte buzzed ball-tossing beach tourists in New England for five days before being recaptured Wednesday.

"He was basically diving at beach-goers, swooping at them," said Eric Aldrich of the New Hampshire Fish and Game Department. "The beach-goers had one thing in common - they were tossing footballs to attract

it. People got a charge out of this."

On Sunday, the bird swooped and lightly scratched the back of a 3-year-old girl at Hampton Beach, N.H., as she ran near two young ballplayers.

Tourists lured the bird close by feeding it, Aldrich said. The same thing, apparently involving the same bird, happened last week at the Fire Island National Seashore on Long Island, N.Y., he said.

Toying with the crushing grip of an eagle's 2-inch talons isn't smart, Aldrich said. But the bird's behavior - the birds normally avoid people - was just as odd.

Raptor Center rehabilitators are at a loss to explain it.

"We didn't see any behavior

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Beach, N.H. The eagle has been flying up and down the beach for several days and has injured three people, including one 8-year-old girl.

Eagle pounces on beach-goers

Raptor from 1A

like that at all," said rehabilitation coordinator Mathias Engelmann. "Obviously, we don't use footballs in rehabilitation."

The center knows little about the bird's history, such as whether it had been in captivity before, Engelmann said. The eagle is believed to have been born last year.

It came to the center May 17 from Kernersville, 70 miles north-east of Charlotte, where it was believed to have been hit by a car. Rehabbers treated it for a mild concussion and a minor eye injury.

The eagle recovered well on a

diet of fish and rats but remained wary of people, Engelmann said. Rehabbers minimize human contact with the birds they're treating.

The bird returned to the wild at Belews Lake, north of Kernersville, on July 25. Wildlife biologists in New Hampshire identified it Tuesday by reading the numbers on its aluminum leg band through a telescope.

New Hampshire biologists speculated the bird might have learned to associate food with people from fishermen tossing fish toward it.

The bird might also have been hungry because of poor hunting skills, experts said.

Attempts to catch the eagle, in-

cluding the use of a small green football, failed in New Hampshire. A flock of state, federal and local biologists Wednesday brought in a net gun from Massachusetts, but the bird flew high and away.

A local animal control officer in Salisbury, Mass., where the bird "strafed a young beach-goer" Wednesday morning, snared the eagle about noon by using beef, ham and a tennis ball as bait, Aldrich said. The bird seemed hungry.

It was to be shipped to Tufts University's wildlife center in Grafton, Mass., for evaluation.

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